

Introduction to Yiruma: The Poet of the Piano

Yiruma (born Lee Ru-ma) is a world-renowned South Korean pianist and composer. He is widely considered a pioneer of the "**New Classical**" or "**Contemporary Classical**" genre. Unlike traditional classical composers, Yiruma focuses on creating music that is accessible, deeply emotional, and profoundly calming, earning him a massive global following in the digital age.

Key Highlights of His Career

- **Global Breakthrough:** Yiruma gained international superstardom with his 2001 album *First Love*, which featured his most famous composition, "**River Flows in You**." This track became a viral sensation and is now considered a modern classic for the piano.
- **Musical Style:** His music is often described as "**sentimental**" and "**minimalist**." He prioritizes melody over technical complexity, using the piano to tell stories that feel intimate and personal. His style bridges the gap between traditional classical music and modern pop sensibilities.
- **Education and Influence:** Educated at King's College London, Yiruma combines European musical foundations with an Eastern sense of serenity and reflection.

Notable Works

- "**River Flows in You**": Often called the "Clair de Lune" of the 21st century.
- "**Kiss the Rain**": A melancholic yet hopeful piece that showcases his ability to evoke strong imagery through sound.
- "**Maybe**": Another staple of his repertoire that highlights his signature delicate touch.

Why He Matters

Yiruma has a unique gift for making the piano feel like a "friend" to the listener. His music is frequently used for relaxation, study, and therapy, proving that **simplicity can be just as powerful as virtuosity**. With billions of views on social media and sold-out concerts worldwide, he remains one of the most streamed instrumental artists in history.

"I want my music to be the soundtrack to people's lives—not something that stands apart, but something that walks beside them."